RAVN DESIGN · ROUND ROBIN · ENGINEERING TRACK

Vello NeighborCard Design Fidelity Audit

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Friday Demo Deliverable

SUMMARY

What we did and why it matters

We asked Claude to generate a NeighborCard for Vello from scratch — the neighbor listing card from the Home screen. The first version looked reasonable, but when we checked it against the design system, we found token drift, data structure errors, and accessibility gaps.

The component has: real provider photo (not initials), verification mark (shield SVG), green "Available" badge, bio, pricing with "from $X / unit", distance with footprints icon in a pill, 5-star rating, and a navigation chevron.

Here we explain what went wrong, how we improved the rules, how the final component turned out, and what questions we still have.

THE MOST VALUABLE ARTIFACT

CLAUDE.md – The rules we give Claude so it doesnt drift

CLAUDE.md is basically an instructions file that Claude reads before generating anything. Its like telling it "these are the rules, dont skip them."

The first version was too simple: it listed 6 colors and said "dont invent." Claude followed the rules... technically. It used those colors, but since they were primitives and not semantic tokens, everything was connected to the wrong value.

What we learned: rules alone arent enough. You also need the full context. Rules without context = output that follows the letter but not the spirit.

Sources we loaded as context:
- Vello Design System (vello-design-system.vercel.app)
- Vello Product Brief (roles, flows, the local trust bet)
- Vello Prototype HTML (the real app classes and structure)
- Interview transcripts (6 from Kestrel Park, June 2026)

And this is how the guardrail improved with each failure:

`Iteration 1 – Weak guardrail`
We gave it 6 raw colors and said "dont invent." Claude used them, but since they were hex and not semantic tokens, everything was tied to the wrong value.

`Iteration 2 – Semantic tokens + data contracts`
Now we required semantic tokens: var(--surface-card), not #FFF. Fixed the data structure and pricing to support the "from $X / unit" pattern.

`Iteration 3 – Accessibility + states`
44px min on buttons, focus ring, prefers-reduced-motion. Card is <button>, not <div>. Verified mark uses native SVG, not Lucide icon.

`Iteration 4 – Integration rules`
After the floating overlay (felt outside the app), we added the rule: use Vellos native nb structure.

The guardrail ended up as a reusable document. The next component starts with better rules.

WHAT WENT WRONG IN CLAUDES OUTPUT

Errors we found reviewing the first version

1. Token drift + semantic color error — valid tokens, wrong meaning

Claude used colors that visually matched Vello but put raw hex instead of design system tokens. The card background used #F6F2E7 (paper) instead of var(--surface-card). The verification mark used a Lucide icon instead of Vellos native shield SVG.

Critically, when the Available badge was added, it used coral/red (--accent, #F0623B) — a valid token but semantically wrong. "Available" is a positive status and must be green. A red dot next to "Available" contradicts the meaning. This was caught during visual review of the rendered screenshot, not during code or token audit.

Corrected to: var(--brand-primary) for text/dot, var(--surface-brand-tint) for background.

2. Data contract — Claude assumed things that arent true

The first version passed rating as just a number (4.9) without stars. Vellos prototype uses 5 filled stars + the number. It also skipped the "available" state entirely.

Distance only supported "min walk" but the prototype has three formats: walk, blocks, and miles. Thats a data model change, not a UI change.

3. Accessibility — Works with mouse but not keyboard

The card is a <button> in the prototype but Claude made it a <div> with onClick. That breaks keyboard nav. The chevron didnt have aria-hidden. The rating stars had no aria-label.

These are measurable rules (WCAG, ARIA). Engineering can check them before shipping.

4. Semantic color error — caught during visual review

After fixing the initial errors, the Available badge was added with --accent (coral, #F0623B) — a valid design token. But "Available" is a positive status; displaying it in red contradicts the meaning. Neither the code audit nor the token audit caught this — it was only visible when reviewing the rendered screenshot.

Before: coral dot + coral text on coral-tinted background
After: green dot (--brand-primary) + green text on --surface-brand-tint background

This reveals a guardrail gap: CLAUDE.md enforced token usage but had no rule about semantic color appropriateness for status indicators.

5. Stars not filled — caught during visual review

The 5-star rating icons rendered as empty outlines instead of filled amber stars. The lucide 'star' icon is stroke-only by default. Users see hollow stars next to '4.9' which looks like 0 stars given — visually contradicting the high rating.

Corrected by replacing outline icon_font stars with filled SVG path shapes using the --rating token (amber-500).

6. Chevron missing circular background

The chevron '>' icon had no background in the generated version. The reference design shows it inside a subtle gray circle, which provides a clearer tap affordance and visual anchor. Added a circular frame with subtle fill around the chevron icon.

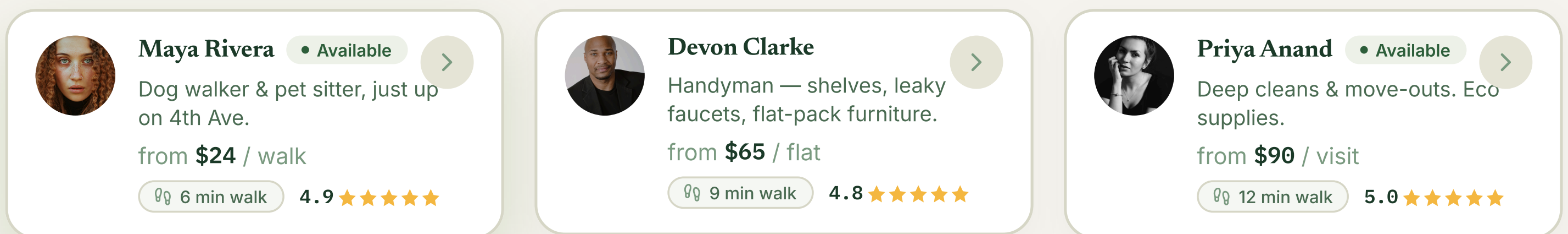
7. Distance pill missing green tint background

The distance pill ('6 min walk') had only a border with no fill. The reference design shows a subtle green-tinted background inside the pill. Added a light green fill to match the reference.

THE FINAL COMPONENT

How it turned out after fixing the errors

This component didnt exist before — we generated it with Claude and corrected it. The final version uses semantic tokens, native shield SVG, structured data with three distance formats, and supports availability states.



`State 1: Available + featured`
Verified, green Available badge, photo, bio, stars, distance pill.

`State 2: Not available`
No Available badge. User knows provider exists but isnt free right now.

`State 3: Perfect rating`
5.0 rating, all stars filled. Available badge present.

AUDIT SUMMARY

What got fixed, specifically

`Token drift (7 properties)`

Card surface
#F6F2E7 (paper) → var(--surface-card)

Available badge
hardcoded coral → var(--brand-primary) green + var(--surface-brand-tint) bg

Verified mark
Lucide ShieldCheck → native Vello shield SVG

Rating stars
hardcoded amber → var(--rating)

Distance pill
div with gray border → pill with var(--border-default)

`Accessibility (5 fixes)`

Root element
<div onClick> → <button type="button">

Decorative chevron
no aria → aria-hidden="true"

Accessible rating
no label → aria-label="Rated 4.9 out of 5"

Avatar photo
<img> without alt → alt={neighbor.name}

Distance formats
walk only → walk, blocks, mi as separate fields

QUESTIONS FOR THE DESIGNER

Things we couldnt resolve without asking

When we reviewed the component, there were values we couldnt trace to any token. Instead of guessing, we left them as open questions.

1. Does NeighborCard use --shadow-md, --shadow-brand (featured), or no shadow?

Why it matters: We used shadow-md for normal and shadow-brand for featured, but we couldnt find the official elevation in the design system.

2. Should the Available badge use var(--accent) with opacity, or is there a specific token?

Why it matters: We used coral at 10% opacity. If theres a semantic token like --surface-accent-tint, we should use that.

3. What happens when a neighbor isnt available — hide the card or show without badge?

Why it matters: Right now we show the card without the badge. The designer might want to gray it out or move it to the end.

4. The verified mark uses var(--brand-primary) for the shield. Is that right or is there a verification-specific token?

Why it matters: The prototype uses var(--green-600) directly. If verification color changes independently, it needs its own token.

WHAT ENGINEERING CONTRIBUTED

Not just implementing – catching when a UI decision is a system decision

- Found invisible drift: Claude used a Lucide icon for verification instead of Vellos native shield SVG.
- Turned the distance model from one format (walk) to three fields (walk, blocks, mi).
- Found that Claude skipped availability entirely. Without the badge, users cant tell if they can book now.
- Changed root from div to button — a tappable card must be a button for keyboard and screen readers.
- Discovered a component can render perfectly and still fail as product: the overlay was outside Vellos flow.
- Caught semantic color error in visual review: the Available badge used coral/red (--accent) — a valid token but wrong meaning for a positive status. Changed to green (--brand-primary). This error passed both code and token audits; only a rendered screenshot revealed it.

SOURCES AND PROCESS

Where each decision came from

This deliverable wasnt built in a vacuum. Every decision traces back to a concrete source:

`Vello Design System`
vello-design-system.vercel.app — Tokens de color (primitivos y semanticos), tipografia (Bricolage, Hanken, JetBrains Mono), escala de spacing 4px, radii, elevaciones, focus ring. Fuente para la tabla de tokens completa en CLAUDE.md.

`Vello Product Brief`
Define los tres roles (Requester, Provider, Community Admin), el scope hiperlocal, y la apuesta central: "trust scales locally." Fuente para las reglas de trust semantics y el contrato de datos en el guardrail.

`Vello Prototype (HTML)`
Archivo HTML descargable con el flujo completo: Home, request, booking, messages, profile, admin. Fuente para las clases nativas (section, neighbors, nb) y la referencia visual. La home screen es la referencia pulida; el resto tiene issues de UX plantados.

`Discovery Interviews (6 transcripts)`
Kestrel Park, junio 2026. Tres requesters, dos providers, un community admin. Evidencia para la separacion de trust signals (verificacion ≠ rating ≠ vouch) y para el pricing no-fijo.

`Claude + CLAUDE.md (el guardrail)`
Claude genero el componente inicial. CLAUDE.md actuo como el contrato del design system para Claude — tokens, trust, datos, a11y, integracion. Se itero 4 veces despues de fallos concretos.

Every correction traces back to one of these sources. Nothing was decided because "it looks fine."

Biggest lesson: three layers of review are needed. (1) Token audit — are tokens correct? (2) Accessibility audit — are elements keyboard-accessible? (3) Visual review — does the rendered output make semantic sense? The coral Available badge passed layers 1 and 2 but failed layer 3. A guardrail that enforces tokens can still miss when a valid token is used in the wrong context.

PROMPTS WE USED

What we asked Claude at each step

The prompts you use say a lot about whether you understand the problem. Here are the ones we used.

`Step 1 – Generate the component`
Context loaded: Vello design system, product brief, CLAUDE.md v1 (weak).

```
"Generate a NeighborCard for Vello using the design system tokens. The card shows: neighbor
photo with verified mark, name, Available badge, bio, pricing with 'from $X / unit', distance
with footprints in a pill, 5-star rating, and a navigation chevron. Its a tappable button. Use
React + Lucide icons. Follow CLAUDE.md rules."
```

Result: Rendered but with drift: raw hex, Lucide icon instead of native SVG shield, no availability, div instead of button.

`Step 2 – Audit token by token`
Context loaded: generated component, full design system, CLAUDE.md v2.

```
"Compare this NeighborCard property by property against the Vello Design System. For each visual
value, tell me: what token it should use, what the component used, whether it matches or
drifted, and the correction. Dont accept 'looks similar' – it has to be the exact token and
native pattern."
```

Found 7 properties with drift. All corrected to semantic tokens.

`Step 3 – Find product and accessibility errors`
Context loaded: corrected component, CLAUDE.md v3 with a11y rules, product brief.

```
"Review this NeighborCard against WCAG: is the card a button or div? Tap targets min 44px?
Chevron has aria-hidden? Stars have aria-label? Photo has alt text? Does Available badge rely on
color alone? Is there prefers-reduced-motion?"
```

Found: div instead of button, chevron without aria-hidden, rating without aria-label. All fixed.

`Step 4 – Integrate into Vello app`
Context loaded: Vello prototype HTML, CLAUDE.md v4 with integration rules.

```
"Integrate the NeighborCard into the Vello HTML prototype using native classes: nb, nb__avatar,
nb__vmark, nb__body, nb__top, nb__name, nb__avail, nb__bio, nb__price, nb__meta, nb__walk,
nb__tap. It should look like another neighbor in the Trusted on your block list."
```

First: overlay (failed). Second: large section (dominated). Third: native nb structure, fit in.

Pattern: each prompt loaded more context. Guardrail updated after each failure. No magic prompt — just generate, review, fix rules, regenerate.